were working together across this kind of network. And the *crème de la crème* of the world hacking community was watching them. I was entering my later teenage years, and the Berlin Wall was about to come down and change everything; a great epochal change in the meaning of ideology that played out on the news every night. But we were already changing the world. When the TVs were switched off, when the parents went to bed, a battalion of young computer hackers were going inside those networks, seeking to create a transformation, I would argue, in the relationship between the individual and the state, between information and governance, that would come in time to partner the wall-breakers in their effort to bust the old order.

Every hacker has a handle, and I took the name Mendax, from Horace's *splendide mendax* – nobly untruthful, or perhaps 'delightfully deceptive'. I liked the idea that in hiding behind a false name, lying about who or where I was, a teenager in Melbourne, I could somehow speak more truthfully about my real identity. By now, the computer work was taking up a great deal of my time. I was beginning to get the hacker's disease: no sleep, bottomless curiosity, single-mindedness, and an obsession with precision. Later, when I became well known, people would enjoy pointing out that I had Asperger's or else that I was dangling somewhere on the autistic spectrum. I don't want to spoil anyone's fun, so let's just say I am – all hackers are, and I would argue all men are, a little bit autistic. But in my mid- to late teens I could barely focus on anything that didn't seem to me like a major breakthrough. Homework was a struggle; ordinary conversation was a chore. In some way I found myself tuning out the local noise, the local weather, to maintain a sense of a frequency that was international. We saw a thousand tasks and became obsessed with exploring those early networks, the internet before the 'Internet'. There was this American system called Arpanet, which, early on, Australians could only connect to if they were part of a university. That's how we piggybacked onto the system. It was certainly addictive, projecting your mind across the world in that way, where every step was unauthorised. First you would have to hack the university computer system, then hack your way back out of it. While inside, you would then hack into some computer system elsewhere in the world – typically, for me at the time, the Pentagon's 8th Command Group computers. You'd dive down into its computer system, taking it over, projecting your mind all the way from your untidy bedroom to the entire